How to Create a Backup of Important Files on a Windows 11 Computer

Document Information

- **Document Title:** How to Create a Backup of Important Files on a Windows 11 Computer
- **Document Type:** Standard Operating Procedure
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Purpose

Backing up your files is important because it ensures you have a copy available if your original files are lost or accidentally deleted. Think of it as a safety net for your important information.

This procedure explains how to back up important files on a Windows 11 computer using easy-to-follow instructions. By the end, you will have successfully copied your selected files to an external USB drive.

Note: This is not the same as a complete Windows backup. This procedure backs up selected personal files.

What You'll Need

- A computer running Windows 11
- An external USB drive with enough available storage space for the files you want to back up.

Before You Begin

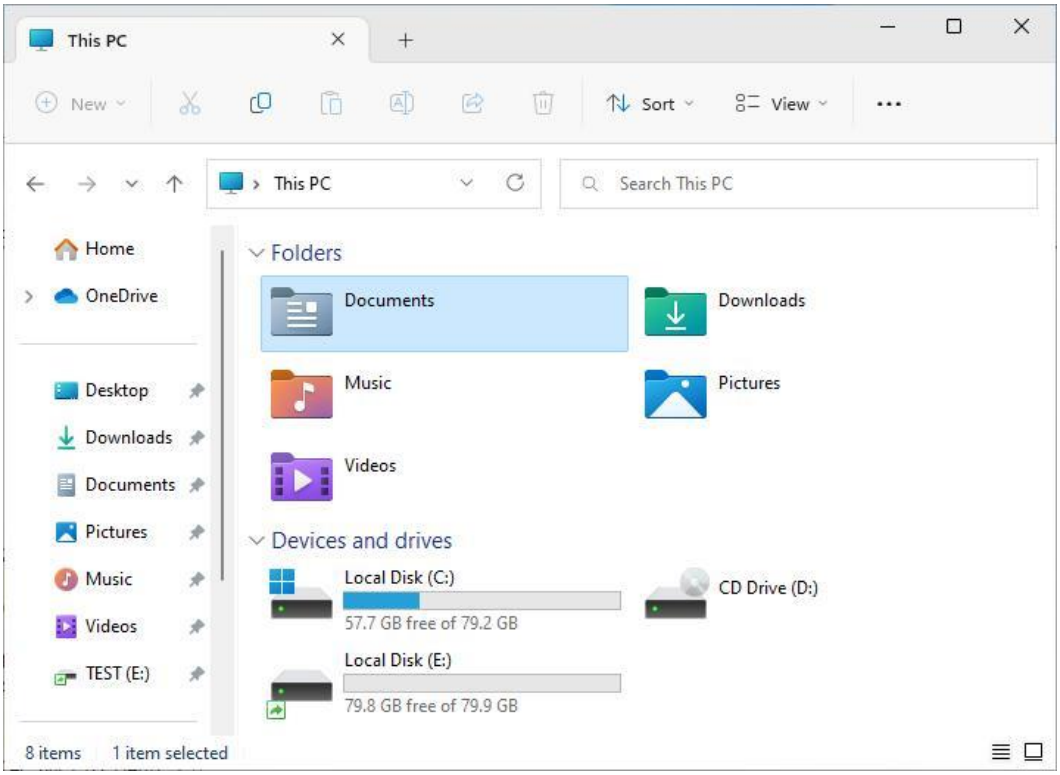
1. Connect the external USB drive to an available USB port on your computer.
2. Open **File Explorer**, select **This PC**, and locate the USB drive under **Drives and devices**. Check the available space displayed beneath the drive.

Safety Warning

- Do not remove the USB drive while files are being transferred.
- Do not delete original files until you've confirmed the backup works.
- Make sure the USB drive is stored somewhere safe after the backup.

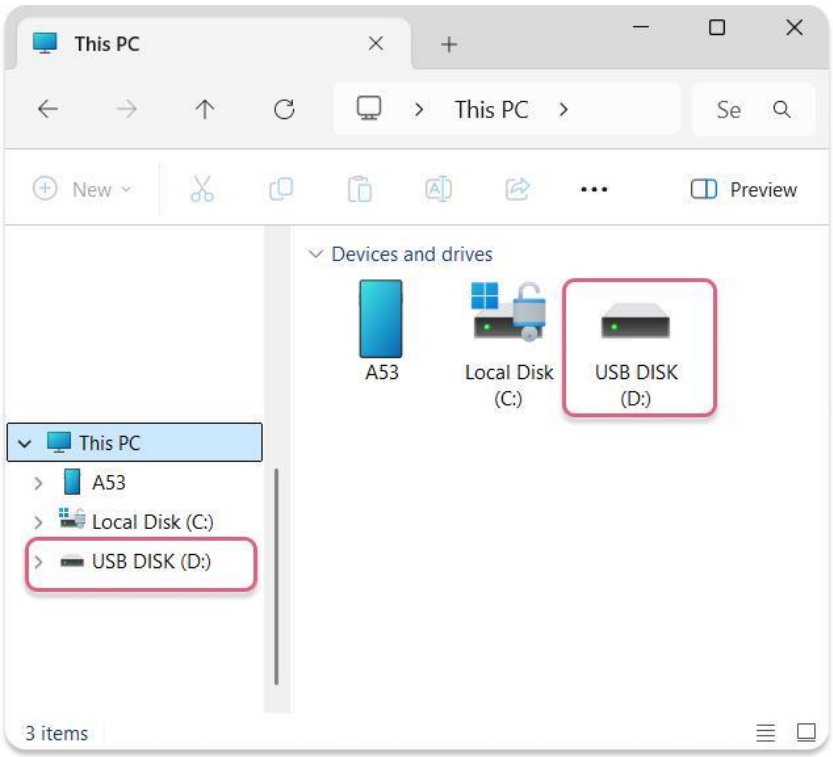
Instructions

1. Open **File Explorer** by clicking the folder icon on the taskbar.
2. Select **This PC** in the navigation pane to view the available drives and connected devices.



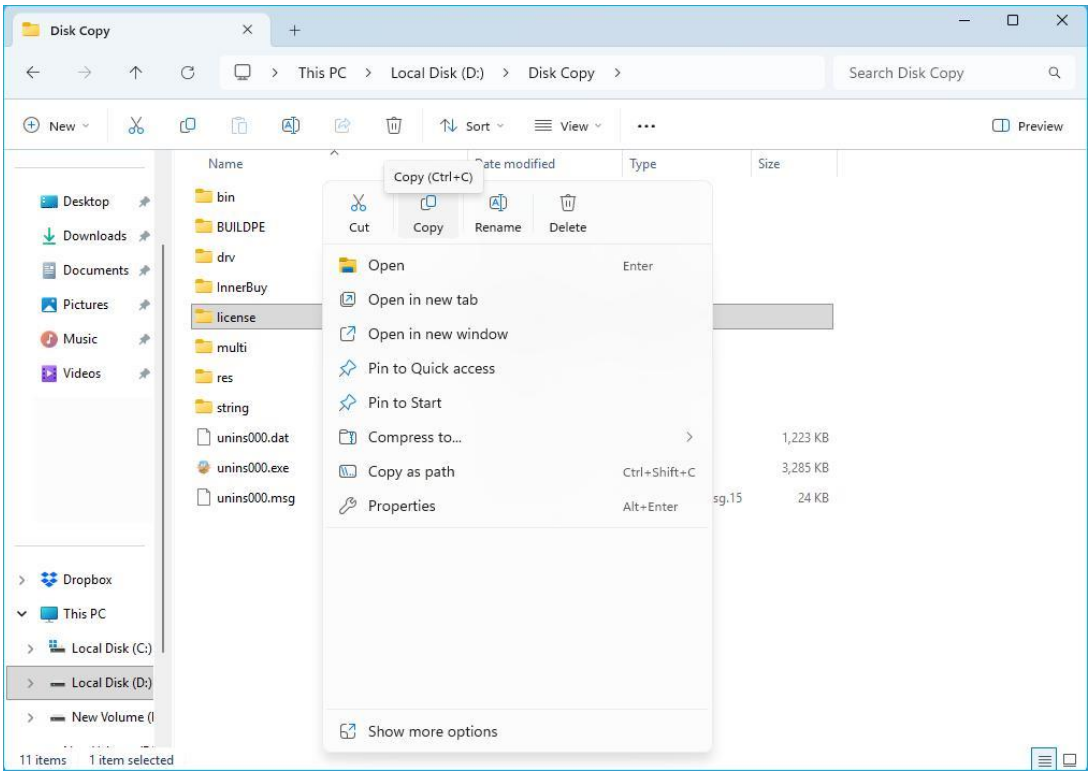
File Explorer with This PC selected.

3. Locate and double-click your external USB drive under **Devices and drives**.



Double-click USB drive under Devices and drives.

4. Locate the original files you want to back up in the **Documents** folder, listed in the navigation pane on the left side of **File Explorer**.
5. Check other folders in **File Explorer** for additional files you want to back up, such as Pictures, Downloads, and Desktop.
6. Select the files you want to back up. To select multiple individual files, hold down the **Ctrl** key while clicking each file.
7. Right-click the selected files and choose **Copy** from the context menu.

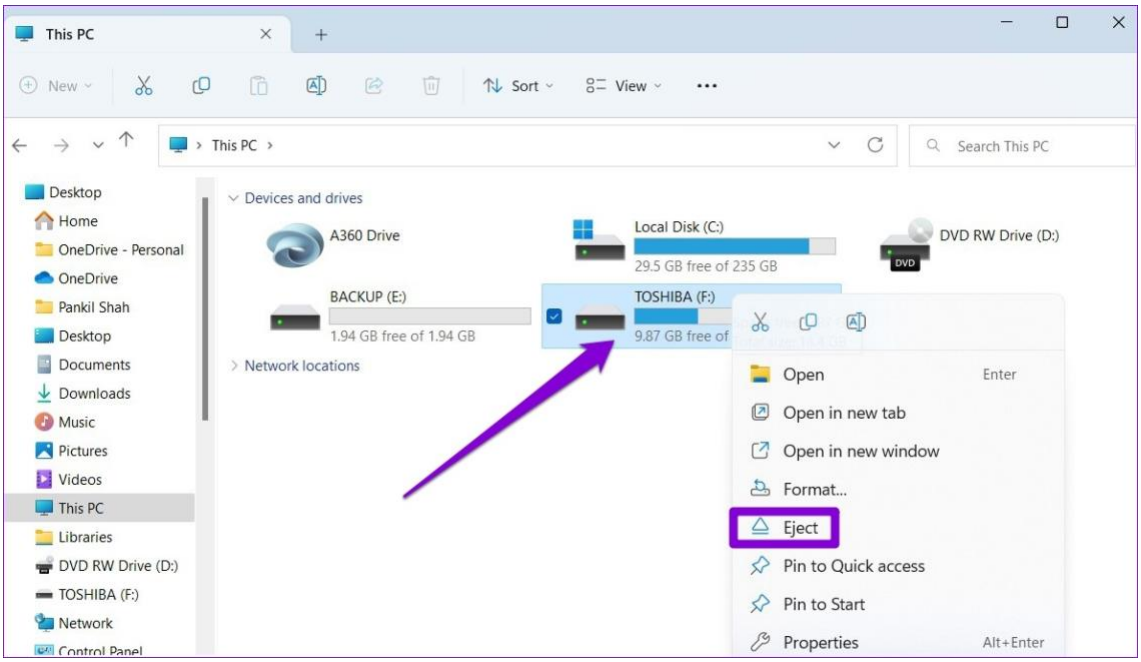


Right-click highlighted files and select **Copy** from context menu.

8. Confirm the drive name and letter then open the external USB drive in **File Explorer.** Right-click an empty area inside the drive's window and select **Paste** from the context menu.
9. After the file transfer is complete, open several files from the USB drive to make sure they can be accessed.
10. Confirm that all the files you selected appear on the USB drive.

Important: Safely Remove Your USB Drive

1. Open **File Explorer** and select **This PC**.
2. Locate your external USB drive under **Devices and drives**.
3. Right-click the USB drive and select **Eject** from the context menu.



Right-click USB drive and select **Eject** from context menu.

4. Wait until Windows indicates that it's safe to remove the device.
5. Disconnect the USB drive from the computer.

This step helps prevent problems that can occur if the USB drive is removed while Windows is still accessing it.

Expected Outcome

- The selected files appear on the USB drive.
- The files open successfully.
- The USB drive has been safely ejected.

Troubleshooting

Problem	*Possible Symptoms*	**Recommended Steps**
USB not detected	Drive does not appear in File Explorer	Reconnect or try another port
Not enough space	Windows displays a storage space warning	Free space or use a larger drive
Files won't copy	Error message or transfer does not complete	Close programs and retry

Problem: USB drive does not appear in File Explorer

Possible Symptoms:

- The USB does not appear under **Devices and drives** in **File Explorer**.
- Windows does not make a notification sound when the USB drive is connected.
- The USB drive appears briefly but then disappears.
- The USB drive appears under a different name than expected.
- The USB drive appears in the **File Explorer** but does not show a drive letter.

Recommended Steps:

1. Disconnect the USB drive and reconnect it to the computer.
2. Try using a different USB port.
3. Open **File Explorer**, select **This PC**, and check whether the drive appears under **Devices and drives**.
4. If none of the steps above worked, restart the computer and check again. If the USB drive still does not appear, the drive or USB port may require further troubleshooting.
5. If the drive does not appear, try connecting it to another computer. If it is not recognized there either, the USB drive may be damaged.

Problem: Not enough storage space on the USB drive.

Possible Symptoms:

- Windows displays a message stating that the destination does not have enough space.
- The file transfer stops before all files have been copied.
- Some files copy successfully, but others do not.
- The remaining available storage is less than the total size of the files being copied.

Recommended Steps:

1. Review the files currently on the USB drive.
2. Delete any unwanted files to free up storage space. Before deleting files, make sure they are no longer needed and that you have another copy of any important information.
3. In **File Explorer**, select **This PC** and check the available space displayed beneath the USB drive.
4. If there still isn't enough space, use a USB drive with a larger storage capacity.

Note: Only delete files you no longer need. Make sure important files have another copy before deleting them from the USB drive.

Problem: Unable to copy files to the USB drive.

Possible Symptoms:

- Windows displays an error message when attempting to copy files.
- The copying process freezes or remains at the same percentage for an extended period.
- The Copy or Paste option is unavailable.
- The file transfer starts but does not complete.

Recommended Steps:

1. Close any programs that may currently be using the files you want to copy.
2. Make sure the files you want to copy are not currently open in another program.
3. Try copying the files again.
4. If the problem continues, restart the computer and reconnect the USB drive.
5. If only one particular file will not copy, try copying a different file. This can help determine whether the problem is related to that specific file.

Problem: Windows displays an error when opening the USB drive.

Possible Symptoms:

- Windows displays an error message when you double-click the USB drive.
- **File Explorer** opens, but the drive's contents cannot be accessed.
- Windows asks you to scan or repair the drive.
- Windows displays a message stating that the drive is inaccessible.
- The USB drive appears in **File Explorer**, but opening it causes **File Explorer** to stop responding.

Recommended Steps:

1. Disconnect the USB drive and reconnect it.
2. Open **File Explorer** and select **This PC**.
3. Right-click the USB drive and select **Properties**.
4. If Windows offers an option to scan or repair the drive, follow the on-screen instructions.
5. If the drive remains inaccessible, stop using it if it contains important files. Consider seeking technical assistance before attempting repairs that could affect the stored data.

Important: Do not format the USB drive if it contains files you need. Formatting can erase its contents.

Problem: Copied files cannot be found on the USB drive.

Possible Symptoms:

- The files do not appear in the USB drive's main folder.
- The USB drive appears to contain fewer files than expected.
- You cannot locate a specific file after completing the transfer.
- The copied files appear to be missing after disconnecting and reconnecting the USB drive.
- The destination folder appears empty even though the copy process indicated it was complete.

Recommended Steps:

1. Open **File Explorer** and select the USB drive.
2. Open the folders on the USB drive and check whether the files were saved inside a folder rather than the main directory.
3. Use the Search box in **File Explorer** to search for the missing file by name.
4. If the files are still missing, repeat the copy process and verify that the transfer completes.

Conclusion

Backing up important files to an external USB drive helps protect personal information from accidental loss or deletion. After completing this procedure, verify that all selected files were copied successfully and can be opened from the USB drive.

Once the backup has been confirmed, safely eject the USB drive before disconnecting it from the computer. Store the drive in a safe location so it is available when needed.